CAREER GLITCH · SHORT · SIMPLE · NO BORING PARTS

UX/UI DESIGNER IN THE AI ERA

AI can generate a thousand screens — it still can't tell you which one a tired nurse can use at 3 a.m.

★ **TL;DR — Median around $105K, remote and freelance-friendly, in a 6–12 month training band. The catch: pretty mockups are commoditized; research and problem-solving are the job now.** ★

THE CAREER GLITCH TAKE

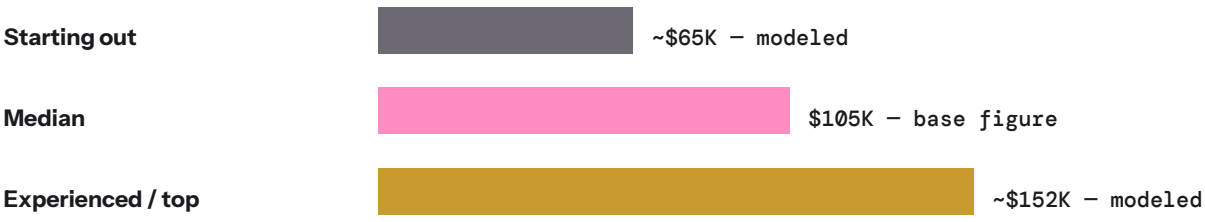
OUR TAKE: YES

MEDIAN ~$105K · TRAINING 6-12 months · AI RISK MEDIUM · CERTIFICATE

- Employers pay for designers who reduce support tickets and raise conversion, not for Dribbble shots.
- Certificate-level entry exists, but the portfolio interview decides everything.
- AI generates UI variations in seconds — taste, research and systems thinking are what's left, and they pay.

The site's take, built from this profession's numbers in the Career Glitch base.

THE MONEY — LOOK AT THE BARS



The Career Glitch base figure for UX/UI Designer is a ~$105K median (compiled from U.S. Bureau of Labor Statistics, Occupational Outlook Handbook ranges). The starting and top bars are modeled around that median — orientation, not a promise. Pay swings hard by state, employer and experience: check live postings in your state before planning around any number.

WHAT DOES A UX/UI DESIGNER ACTUALLY DO?

✓ Interview users and watch them struggle with the product

- ✓ Map flows, wireframe and prototype in Figma
- ✓ Run usability tests and argue from evidence, not taste
- ✓ Hand off design systems and specs to developers

Think: an architect for software — you draw nothing decorative until the structure works for the people inside it.

WHAT AI ALREADY TOOK (AND WHAT IT CAN'T)

THE ROBOT	THE HUMAN
AI drafts screens, icons, illustrations and first-pass layouts instantly. Pure visual execution — the old junior design task — is being absorbed.	Understanding users, choosing between trade-offs, accessibility judgment and convincing a room full of engineers with evidence. Research and strategy stay human.

⚠ **The market is flooded with bootcamp portfolios that all look identical. A generic case-study template is now a negative signal.**

THE VIBE — IS THIS YOUR LIFE?

THE JOB IS	THE JOB IS NOT
✓ Remote work and a real freelance path ✓ Visible work — you see your designs ship ✓ A mix of psychology, visuals and logic	✗ Endless revision rounds driven by opinions ✗ Your work judged in the first 5 seconds of a portfolio review ✗ Pixel arguments with stakeholders who 'just don't like it'

Good fit? You notice bad interfaces everywhere, you like talking to users, and you can defend a decision with evidence instead of ego.
Bad fit? You want to make art alone in silence — this is a meeting-heavy, argument-heavy job.

THE FORK — PICK ONE DOOR

DOOR A — PORTFOLIO PROGRAM	DOOR B — FREELANCE AND REDESIGNS
Take a structured UX course or certificate, then produce 3 deep case studies: problem, research, iterations, test results. Depth beats volume at every review.	Start with real small clients: redesign a local business's booking flow or app, measure the difference, and turn paid work into case studies with numbers.

Smart move: Redesign one famous app's weakest flow and document your user tests publicly. Hiring managers share strong teardowns — it travels further than any certificate.
Where you land after: Senior product designer → design lead, or a pivot into product management and design systems.

YOUR ROADMAP — 6 STEPS

1	2	3	4	5	6
LEARN THE	LEARN UX	FIRST FULL	TWO MORE,	REAL-WORLD REPS	APPLY WITH

STEP 1 — Learn the tool and the basics

FREE · WEEKS 1-3

- Figma to a working standard — components, auto-layout, prototyping.
- Design fundamentals: hierarchy, spacing, typography, color.

STEP 2 — Learn UX process, not just UI

FREE-$300 · WEEKS 4-8

- User research, journey mapping, wireframing, usability testing methods.
- Complete a recognized UX certificate course if you want structure and a credential line.

STEP 3 — First full case study

FREE · MONTHS 2-3

- One end-to-end project with real user interviews and a tested prototype.
- Write it as a story: problem → evidence → decisions → outcome.

STEP 4 — Two more, different flavors

FREE · MONTHS 3-5

- Add a mobile app and a dense dashboard/web product.
- Include one accessibility-focused pass — it signals senior thinking.

STEP 5 — Real-world reps

FREE-PAID · MONTHS 4-8

- Freelance gigs, internships or volunteer redesigns for real organizations.
- Collect before/after metrics wherever possible.

STEP 6 — Apply with the portfolio first

FREE · MONTHS 6-12

- Your case studies are the application; the resume is a formality.
- Practice whiteboard design challenges — they are half of every interview loop.

FIRST 90 DAYS — JUST DO THIS

- Today: install Figma and recreate one app screen you use daily, pixel for pixel.
- Days 1–30: fundamentals done; first wireframes and a small tested prototype.
- Days 31–60: UX process course underway; user interviews for case study #1 completed.
- Days 61–90: case study #1 published; case study #2 scoped with real users lined up.

□ Day 90: a live portfolio with one deep case study and a second in progress.

NEXT — MAKE IT PERSONAL

This roadmap is the same for everyone. Your life is not.

- Not sure this career fits YOU? Take the Big Career Test — 50 questions, your top-3 matches and one honest “probably NOT you”. → careerglitch.com/#test
- Already sure? Turn AI into Your Personal Career Mentor — a 2,300-word system that interviews you first, checks your hours, budget and deadline honestly, and builds YOUR plan into a Notion dashboard. → careerglitch.com/#prompt

★ AI DRAWS SCREENS. DESIGNERS SOLVE PROBLEMS. ★

CAREER GLITCH · Figures: Career Glitch profession base (medians and training ranges compiled from U.S. Bureau of Labor Statistics, Occupational Outlook Handbook ranges). Modeled bars are estimates around the base median. License and certification rules vary by state — verify with your state board before paying for any program.